

Where heavyweights and hopefuls collide

Neeladri Bhattacharjee
neeladri.b@thehindu.co.in

Spain arrives at the gates of the 2026 World Cup heavy on reputation and loaded with tactics. The 2023 Nations League and 2024 European champion has not lost a competitive match in the last three years and topped its World Cup qualification group, scoring 21 goals while conceding just two.

The team's biggest strength will lie in the engine room, where Ballon d'Or winner Rodri will pull the strings to keep the house in order. Meanwhile, Pedri — one of only two players in Europe's top seven leagues in the 80 percentile for key passes, progressive carries and duel-win percentage — will serve as the

runner, orchestrating attacks and stopping counters before the halfway line.

Coach Luis de la Fuente will hope marauding wingers Lamine Yamal and Nico Williams get fit in time to keep his wing-play tactics on course, while Mikel Oyarzabal, who inspired Real Sociedad to its first Copa del Rey title in five years, is expected to attack more centrally.

The 2010 world champion will face debutant Cape Verde in its opener, which could see Spain go with a rotated squad. The tiny African team, despite entering the tournament as a minnow, has beaten Cameroon and Ghana in the last two years. Under the tutelage of former player-turned-manager Pedro



SPAIN

FIFA ranking: 2

Appearances: 16

Best finish: Winner (2010)

Matches: 67

Wins: 31

Draws: 17

Losses: 19

Goals For: 108

Goals Against: 75

Highest scorer in the squad

Mikel Oyarzabal (24 goals)



CAPE VERDE

FIFA ranking: 68

Appearances: Debut

Highest scorer in the squad Ryan Mendes (22 goals)

